



△ *Eve of the Battle of Edgehill*, Charles Landseer, 1845

▽ The Chongzhen Emperor with his empress



1644

FALL OF THE MING

By the 1640s, Ming China was in terminal decline. Ravaged by drought and disease, parts of the empire rose in revolt. In spring 1644, the most powerful peasant leader, Li Zicheng, marched on Beijing. The Chongzhen Emperor hanged himself from a tree in the imperial gardens and Li Zicheng was proclaimed emperor of a new dynasty. However, his triumph proved short-lived.

1644 At the Battle of Marston Moor, Parliamentarians defeat the Royalists in the English Civil War

1644

1643 At the Battle of Rocroi the French victory over Spain leaves France the leading European nation

1643 Italian physicist Evangelista Torricelli uses a mercury barometer to measure atmospheric pressure

As many as one in 25 of the English population died in the Civil Wars

1644

THE MANCHU INVADE CHINA

Exploiting the chaos surrounding the fall of the Ming, Manchu armies penetrated the Great Wall, asserting their claim to rule China as the Qing dynasty. With the aid of Ming generals hostile to the rebel Li Zicheng, the Manchu achieved victory at the Battle of Shanhai Pass and occupied Beijing. Led by the Regent, Dorgon, they embarked on a series of brutal military campaigns to extend their rule over the whole of the Chinese empire.



△ Prince-Regent Dorgon, Manchu regent